coordination and no common programme,' is how a member described the change. Sonia herself had to step away from the NAC in 2006 over the office-of-profit controversy when she was accused of violating a rule that as an MP, she could not hold another 'paid' post. She only returned in 2010. By then, the group had lost its sheen.

Not everyone in the government saw the NAC in benign terms. More than one minister told me there was no place for a 'super-Cabinet' in the Indian political system. 'It's only there to satisfy Sonia Gandhi's ego,' was one sharp criticism I heard often. Pawar, for example, felt that the NAC was, as he told a colleague, 'a group of busybodies who are undermining the Cabinet system'. Pawar, who had been in politics for close to five decades, was incensed when the NAC tried to fast-track the food security legislation during UPA-II. 'We must not do anything in a hurry like this,' he warned the prime minister, who was also worried about the financial costs in a period of economic slowdown. Pawar found support in deputy chairperson of the Planning Commission, Montek Singh Ahluwalia, whom the prime minister trusted implicitly. 'We tried to convince Soniaji but she was just not willing to listen,' Pawar told me later.

In the end, the Manmohan–Pawar–Montek combine had to yield ground to the authority of a Sonia-led initiative that aimed to provide subsidized foodgrains to approximately two-thirds of the country's 1.2 billion people. With Sonia holding firm, the bill was passed in September 2013. One estimate put the cost at Rs 125,000 crore. Even if the final figure was lower, there were still legitimate concerns over fiscal and inflationary pressures. 'You must understand Sonia Gandhi,' an aide told me later. 'She doesn't trust economists but goes by her political instincts, and her instincts told her that food security would be a political winner.' What she forgot was that many Opposition-ruled states had already initiated efficient foodgrain distribution programmes. At the fag end of its tenure, the Congress leadership was clutching at straws.

While the NAC was branded a civil society–state interface, Sonia had a more direct political involvement through a Friday evening 'core group' meeting at the prime minister's residence at 7, Race Course Road. This was